

❖ STUDY BEES ❖

POEM – WIND

by
Robert Louis Stevenson

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About the Poem

"The Wind" is a three-stanza poem by Robert Louis Stevenson, taken from his famous children's poetry collection *A Child's Garden of Verses* (1885). Each stanza is a sestet (six lines) written in simple, musical language suited to a child's point of view. The poem is spoken by a child who watches the many effects of the wind – tossing kites, blowing birds, rustling through the grass – and wonders about the invisible force that causes them, eventually asking the wind directly what kind of being it is.

Paraphrasing

Stanza 1:

*I saw you toss the kites on high
And blow the birds about the sky;
And all around I heard you pass,
Like ladies' skirts across the grass—
O wind, a-blowing all day long,
O wind, that sings so loud a song!*

Paraphrasing:

The speaker says he watched the wind toss kites high into the sky and blow birds off course. He could hear it moving all around him, and its soft rushing sound reminded him of long skirts sweeping across the grass. He then addresses the wind directly, remarking that it blows all day long and seems to sing a loud, cheerful song.

Stanza 2:

*I saw the different things you did,
But always you yourself you hid.
I felt you push, I heard you call,
I could not see yourself at all—
O wind, a-blowing all day long,
O wind, that sings so loud a song!*

Paraphrasing:

The child says he saw all the different things the wind did to the world around him, yet the wind itself always stayed hidden and out of sight. He could feel it pushing against him and hear it calling out, but he could never actually see it. He repeats the same refrain, marvelling at its constant, singing presence.

Stanza 3:

*O you that are so strong and cold,
O blower, are you young or old?
Are you a beast of field and tree,
Or just a stronger child than me?
O wind, a-blowing all day long,
O wind, that sings so loud a song!*

Paraphrasing:

In the final stanza, the child questions the wind about its true nature. He asks whether this strong, cold force is young or old, whether it is some kind of wild creature living among the fields and trees, or simply a child like himself, only far stronger. The poem closes with the same joyful refrain about the wind's endless blowing and singing.

Rhyming Scheme

The poem is made up of three sestet (six-line stanzas), each following an AABBCB rhyme scheme. The first two lines rhyme with each other (*high / sky*), the third and fourth lines form a second rhyming pair (*pass / grass*), and the final two lines are an identical refrain (*long / song*) repeated at the end of every stanza. This repeated closing couplet gives the poem a strong musical, song-like unity that suits its light, childlike tone.

Theme

"The Wind" captures a child's wonder at the power and mystery of an invisible natural force. Although the wind can never be seen, its effects – on kites, birds, grass and the speaker's own body – are everywhere. The poem celebrates curiosity and imagination, showing how a child makes sense of the unknown by questioning it directly and comparing it to familiar things (a beast, a stronger child). At its heart, the poem is about the joy of noticing and wondering about the ordinary mysteries of nature.

Figures of Speech

• Personification

The wind is treated as a living being capable of tossing, hiding, pushing, calling and singing, and is addressed throughout as "you."

• Apostrophe

The speaker directly addresses the wind as though it can hear and answer him ("O wind...", "O you that are so strong and cold").

• Simile

The sound of the wind moving through the grass is compared to the rustle of "ladies' skirts across the grass."

• Refrain

The couplet "O wind, a-blowing all day long, / O wind, that sings so loud a song!" is repeated at the end of each stanza, reinforcing the poem's musical quality.

- **Rhetorical Questions**

The final stanza is built around questions the speaker cannot answer ("Are you young or old?"), reflecting a child's genuine curiosity about the unseen.

- **Auditory Imagery**

Words like "heard," "push," "call" and "sings" appeal strongly to the sense of hearing, since the wind can only be perceived, never seen.

Questions & Answers

Q1. What does the speaker see the wind doing in the first stanza?

He sees the wind toss kites high into the sky and blow birds off course, and hears it rushing around him like skirts sweeping over the grass.

Q2. Why is the sound of the wind compared to ladies' skirts?

The comparison (a simile) captures the soft, continuous rustling sound the wind makes as it sweeps through the grass.

Q3. What puzzles the speaker most about the wind?

He is puzzled that he can feel, hear and see the wind's effects everywhere, yet the wind itself always stays hidden and is never actually visible.

Q4. What questions does the speaker ask the wind in the final stanza?

He asks whether the wind is young or old, whether it is a wild beast of the fields and trees, or simply a child stronger than himself.

Q5. What is the effect of the repeated refrain in the poem?

The refrain "O wind, a-blowing all day long, O wind, that sings so loud a song!" gives the poem a musical, song-like rhythm and emphasises the wind's constant, joyful presence.

Q6. What is the central theme of the poem?

The poem celebrates a child's curiosity and sense of wonder at the invisible, ever-present power of nature.